INDIA TODAY RPG Happiness Quest

Gratitude: *The Key to Happiness*

Peace and contentment—the building blocks of true happiness—can only come from recognising the value of what you already have



By **JAYA ROW**



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Happiness depends on our attitude—are we looking at the things we have or the things we don't have? You can have immense material wealth, but if you focus on the one or two things that you don't have, you will be unhappy. In Indian mythology, Sudama had nothing but he lived in a state of abundance.

Some of the most precious things that we have in life come free—the oxygen we breathe, wonderful family relationships or the good health we enjoy. The moment you become aware of all that you have, you become immensely grateful towards some power that has bestowed these blessings on you and then happiness automatically follows.

We must remember that in life we get what we deserve, not what we desire, and what we deserve is a result of the choices we have made in the past.

How to find happiness...

- **Focus on what you have.** This awareness leads to gratitude and puts your mind in a calm and peaceful state. When your mind is content and calm, your intellect becomes sharper and you are able to think clearly. That helps bring out the best in you which, in turn, helps you achieve more in life. Being content doesn't mean you shouldn't aspire for more.
- **Give.** Even before the actual act of giving, the very thought of giving can make you happy. You can give emotions, love, concern, knowledge and compassion. When you give, you gain, but when you grab, you lose. We haven't understood that. So, we are takers and not givers.
- **Begin your day by writing down five things you are blessed with.** You may or may not believe in god, but be aware of the power that has given you multiple blessings.
- **Teach children the joy of giving.** They will grow into successful, fulfilled and happy adults! Instead of telling them to do well so that they can make money, teach children how to work to serve people. That will bring them true happiness. ■

Jaya Row *is a spiritual leader and founder of Vedanta Vision (As told to Aditi Pai)*

What makes me *happy*

"Happiness for me is a state of mind. It is not dependent on material gains. I am happiest when the work we do gives joy to others. The idea of happiness has gone through a tumultuous change during the pandemic. Today, the quality of our thoughts matters more than our physical possessions because happiness cannot be owned or locked up in a box—it breathes and blossoms when we experience every minute of life with hope, grace, gratitude and humility"



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